I didn't hear from him immediately, but when I called him on June 20, he said he would take it. It was only 3,000 words long (the joke wouldn't carry for longer than that), but $60 was a pleasant sum

for a couple of hours' work on each of four days, and I was delighted when the check arrived on August 15.

By July 1, I had some 12,000 words of first draft done on "Grow Old with Me," and I took it in to Merwin as proof I was working. To my not-altogether-pleased surprise, he asked to read it, and told me to come back in the afternoon. I did and he told me he had looked over it, liked it, and only hoped I could keep it up. I assured him I could.

28

On June 26, 1947, meanwhile, Stanley was graduated from Brooklyn Technical High School, a month before his eighteenth birthday. Gertrude and I held the fort in the candy store while the rest of the family attended the exercises.

Stanley planned to go to New York University and had gotten a $ioo-a-year scholarship there. My father shook his head and said that a $2oo-a-year scholarship was required. (Tuition fees had risen since my day.) There was still the possibility of a state scholarship, however.

When I learned of this, I promptly said that if the state scholarship didn't come through, I could make up the $ioo-a-year difference myself.

I made the offer eagerly. I was proud that my savings from the Navy Yard and the Army and that my earnings from my writings made it possible to offer $400 without its seriously affecting my solvency. My father, however, flatly refused my repeated offer.

29

In early July, we received letters from Bob Heinlein that pointedly did not mention Leslyn, and Gertrude said, at once, that they were splitting up.

I refused to believe it, but she was right, of course. A letter from Sprague confirmed it. I promptly wrote to Bob expressing sympathy over his marital problems, and he wrote back just as promptly saying he had no marital problems. I took it to mean that his marital problems had been solved by separation, so I said no more.